INTERVIEW

**Shivraj Singh Chouhan**
*Chief Minister, Madhya Pradesh*

# "If BJP asks me to spread carpets, I will"

*Madhya Pradesh CM* **SHIVRAJ SINGH CHOUHAN** *spoke to India Today Group Editorial Director (Publishing)* **RAJ CHENGAPPA** *and India Today Hindi Editor* **SAURABH DWIVEDI**. *Excerpts:*

**Q. The PM has spoken out against the freebie culture. What is your stand on it?**
I agree with the PM—competitive freebie disbursal for votes is wrong. But the poorest have a right over resources too and help and support for their basic necessities are needed.

**Q. How do you intend to provide the 3.2 million jobs you have promised? It seems a tall order.**
We will provide these jobs by announcing government recruitment, dovetailing self-employment schemes and even through all the women SHGs.

**Q. In your earlier tenures, Kailash Vijayvargiya was a potential challenger and now home minister Narottam Mishra has taken over that role. Your fourth term is not going unchallenged?**
Kailash Vijayvargiya is a close friend from childhood and Narottamji is a trusted co-worker. Even the friends who have come from the Congress are now one with us. Like I said earlier, they have become one like sugar dissolves in milk.

**Q. The last election saw the slogan 'Hamara neta Shivraj, maaf karo Maharaj', and in this term, you are working with Jyotiraditya Scindia. How does this understanding come about in politics?**
If you don't have an ego, if you can take everyone with you, love can move mountains. I'm not saying this for effect, but I have not faced any problems working with Jyotiraditya Scindia or the other Congress leaders who joined us.

**Q. Why are you not part of the reshuffled BJP parliamentary board?**
The party decides what work one will do. There is a team that decides what work is to be done by whom. You think about the country and the party will think of you.... The party has given me so much; tomorrow, if it asks me to spread carpets at functions, I would do that too.

**Q. What initiatives are you planning in agriculture?**
The PM is working towards enhancing farm incomes. We are giving financial support to small farmers. We procure crops and provide remunerative prices but, in the future, crop diversification is a must. As a result, medicinal plants like *ashwagandha* are also being cultivated. We give subsidies to MSMEs and we will give farmers similar support for agricultural implements.

**Q. From mama to Bulldozer mama, what explains the transformation?**
We have been soft on good people and tough on criminals from the beginning. Recently, those who had encroached on government land have been targeted by the bulldozer. These lands will be redistributed to the poor. What's wrong with that? ■

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▲ **KEYNOTE ADDRESS: MADHYA PRADESH FIRST**

## TAKEAWAYS

- Madhya Pradesh is committed to the environment as seen in the commissioning of non-renewable energy projects. A 600 MW 'floating' solar power project has been announced at the Omkareshwar dam recently. The state was the 'Tiger State' and 'Leopard State', and is soon to become the 'Cheetah State' with cheetahs from Africa to be introduced at Kuno-Palpur National Park
- The state has planned two road infrastructure projects—the North-South Atal Expressway and the East-West Narmada Expressway—alongside which industrial townships will be set up
- In a first, the MBBS course at the Gandhi Medical College in Bhopal will be taught in Hindi
- A total of 3.2 million jobs, through government employment and self-employment schemes, will be created in the state
- Four million women in the state are linked to self-help groups (SHGs) that are engines of economic growth too